MERIT USER GUIDE

Who sees what, and your profiles

A plain-language guide to how MERIT decides what you can see and do, how access is given out, and how to use profiles and switch between them.

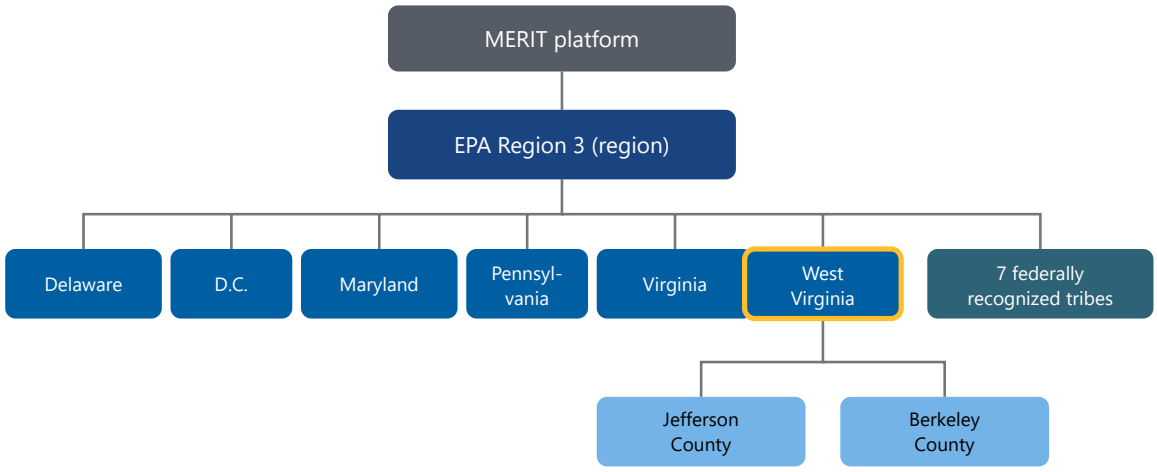
In one minute

- MERIT is organized like a family tree of agencies. You see the records of the agency you work for, and everything under it. You never see your neighbors' records.
- Your **master profile** is everything you have been given. Only an administrator can change it.
- You can make smaller **profiles** for everyday work, such as "read only" or "just one county", and switch between them at any time. A profile can never give you more than your master profile.
- Administrators can **view MERIT as** someone they manage, to check what that person can see.

The examples use EPA Region 3 (Delaware, the District of Columbia, Maryland, Pennsylvania, Virginia, West Virginia and seven federally recognized tribes). The people and screens are made up, to show how things work.

1. The tree: how MERIT is organized

Every agency that uses MERIT is a **tenant**. Tenants are arranged in a tree, from the top down:



Platform: manages accounts only. Region and states: their own records and everything below. Counties: their own records.

The one rule to remember

> **You see the records of the place you work for, and of every place under it. Nothing beside it, and nothing above it.**

- A **Pennsylvania** case manager sees Pennsylvania records. They **cannot** see Delaware's, or any other state's.
- A **West Virginia** case manager sees West Virginia's records, including Jefferson County's and Berkeley County's.
- A **Jefferson County** case manager sees Jefferson County only. Not Berkeley, and not the rest of the state.
- An **EPA Region 3** staff member sees all six states and the tribes, because they are all under the region.

Think of an office building. The region has the whole building, each state has a floor, and each county has a room on its floor. Your key opens your space and the rooms inside it, never the floor next door.

Not everyone has every level

Each organization uses only the levels it needs. Maryland on its own would have the platform, a state and its counties. Baltimore City on its own would have the platform and one jurisdiction. The rules are the same however tall the tree is.

> **Shared lists stay in their own state.** Each state (and each tribe) keeps its own address list, laboratory list, levels and settings. Pennsylvania users never see Delaware's address list either.

2. Words you will see

Tenant
An agency or program in the tree: the platform, a region, a state, a tribe, a program or a county.

Home tenant ("Works for")
The agency you work for. Its administrators manage your account: your name, password reset and second factor.

Role
A named set of things you can do, such as *Case manager*, *Supervisor* or *User administrator*.

Grant
One line of access: *a role, at a place, with or without everything under it, at an access level*. For example: "Case manager at Jefferson County, read and write".

Access level
Read only: look, but change nothing. **Read and write**: add and change records, but not delete them. **Full**: read, write and delete. (Deleted records are hidden, not destroyed: MERIT keeps them, with who deleted them and when.)

Master profile
All of your grants together: the most you can ever do. Only an administrator can change it. You cannot change or switch it off yourself.

Profile
A smaller version of your master profile that you make for yourself, such as "Read only - Berkeley". You choose which profile you are using.

Working in
The tenant your new records belong to, such as the county you are working on today.

View as
An administrator tool to see MERIT the way someone they manage sees it, without knowing that person's password.

Your access is a list of grants

Role	Place	Including everything under it?	Access level
Case manager	Jefferson County	Yes	Full
Case manager	Berkeley County	Yes	Full

This is the master profile of Bailey, who works for both Jefferson and Berkeley counties (see section 3).

3. Who can do what: EPA Region 3

Here are the kinds of people MERIT expects, using EPA Region 3 as the example.

The platform administrator

Example: Pat, on the MERIT platform team. Pat was the first account ever created.

What Pat does: creates, changes and deactivates accounts for everyone; gives and removes roles; manages each person's master profile; and adds new regions, states, tribes and counties on the **Tenants** screen.

What Pat cannot do: see, add, change or delete any records about people, results, cases or investigations. Pat sees only what is needed to manage accounts: names, user names, work email and who has which role. Health information stays invisible. Pat also has just one profile and cannot switch profiles or view as others: managing accounts is the job.

EPA Region 3 administrator

Example: Reese. Roles: Administrator and Supervisor at EPA Region 3, and everything under it.

Sees: every state's, tribe's and county's records in Region 3.

Does: regional work, plus manages accounts for anyone who works in Region 3: adds people, gives roles at any place in the region, ends access and resets second factors.

Can view as: anyone in Region 3, such as a West Virginia case manager.

EPA Region 3 staff member

Example: Sky. Role: Supervisor at EPA Region 3, and everything under it.

Sees and works on: records in every Region 3 state, tribe and county.

Cannot: manage accounts or give access to anyone.

Tip: when entering a West Virginia result, set *Working in* to West Virginia, so the record uses West Virginia's levels and settings.

West Virginia administrator

Example: Wren. Roles: Administrator and Supervisor at West Virginia, and everything under it.

Sees: West Virginia and all of its counties. **Not** Pennsylvania, Delaware or the region's own records.

Does: manages accounts for people who work in West Virginia or its counties, and changes West Virginia's settings and levels.

Can view as: West Virginia and county staff, for example to check a new hire's access.

West Virginia staff member

Example: Morgan. Role: Case manager at West Virginia, and everything under it.

Sees and works on: West Virginia records, including Jefferson's and Berkeley's.

Cannot: see any other state, or manage accounts.

Jefferson County administrator

Example: Jamie. Roles: User administrator and Case manager at Jefferson County.

Sees: Jefferson County records only.

Does: adds new people, who must work in Jefferson; gives Jefferson access to people (including people from other counties); ends Jefferson access. Jamie can only give roles Jamie has at Jefferson, so Jamie cannot hand out state-level powers.

Cannot: change accounts of people who work elsewhere, or give access in Berkeley.

Can view as: Jefferson staff, and only the Jefferson part of anyone who also works elsewhere.

Jefferson County staff member

Example: Jordan. Role: Case manager at Jefferson County.

Sees and works on: Jefferson County records only.

Cannot: see Berkeley or the rest of West Virginia, or manage accounts.

A staff member who works for Jefferson and Berkeley counties

Example: Bailey. Works for Jefferson (home tenant). Grants: Case manager at Jefferson County, and Case manager at Berkeley County.

How Bailey got there: Jamie (the Jefferson administrator) created Bailey's account and gave the Jefferson role. Then the Berkeley administrator found Bailey by user name and gave the Berkeley role. Each administrator manages only their own county's part.

Sees and works on: Jefferson and Berkeley records, but not the rest of West Virginia or any other state.

Profiles that help: "Berkeley only" for a day of Berkeley home visits, or "Read only" for a records review.

At a glance

Person	Sees records of	Can change records?	Manages accounts for	Can switch profiles / view as?
Platform administrator	**None**	**No**	Everyone	**No / No**
Region 3 administrator	All of Region 3	**Yes**	People in Region 3	**Yes / Yes**
Region 3 staff	All of Region 3	**Yes**	**No one**	**Yes**
West Virginia administrator	West Virginia and its counties	**Yes**	People in WV	**Yes / Yes**
West Virginia staff	West Virginia and its counties	**Yes**	**No one**	**Yes**
Jefferson administrator	Jefferson	**Yes**	People in Jefferson	**Yes / Yes**
Jefferson staff	Jefferson	**Yes**	**No one**	**Yes**
Jefferson and Berkeley staff	Jefferson and Berkeley	**Yes**	**No one**	**Yes**
Pennsylvania staff	Pennsylvania **(not Delaware)**	**Yes**	**No one**	**Yes**

Rules administrators can count on

- **You give only what you have.** You can give a role at a place only if you have those abilities there yourself. A county administrator cannot hand out state-wide powers. (The platform administrator is the exception: giving access is the platform administrator's job.)
- **You manage only your part of the tree.** You manage accounts of people who work for your place or below it. For people who work elsewhere, you can give or end access only in your own place.
- **Nobody changes their own master profile.** Not even an administrator. Another administrator must do it.
- **Nobody can deactivate their own account**, or reset their own second factor.
- **Changes take effect at once.** When you change someone's grants, they are signed out of open sessions and start fresh with the new access.

4. Your master profile and your other profiles

A better way to think about it: your keys

Your **master profile** is like the master key to your office. It opens everything you are allowed into. Carrying it all day is risky: if you mistakenly open the wrong door, it opens. So most people keep the master key in the drawer and carry a **day key** that opens just the rooms they need today.

In MERIT, a **profile** is that day key. You make it from your master key: it can open fewer doors, or let you look without touching, but it can never open a door your master key cannot.

> **Compared with a cloud account's "root user":** Cloud services tell you not to use the all-powerful root account for everyday work. MERIT builds that advice in. Your master profile is your root account, and your everyday profiles are smaller, safer copies of it that you can switch between in a click.

Why have extra profiles?

- **Fewer mistakes.** When you are only reviewing records, a read-only profile means you cannot change or delete anything by accident.
- **Focus.** A "Berkeley only" profile keeps your lists, queues and searches to the county you are working on today.
- **Safer screen sharing and training.** Use a read-only profile when presenting or training others.
- **No deleting by accident.** A "read and write, no delete" profile lets you work normally while protecting records from deletion.
- **Easy to undo.** You can switch back to your master profile at any time, without signing out.

The rules

You can	You cannot
• Create as many extra profiles as you like • Rename and change them • Deactivate them (hide them from the switcher) • Switch between any of your active profiles • Go back to your master profile at any time	• Give a profile more than your master profile has: a bigger role, another place, or a higher access level • Change or deactivate your master profile • Keep using a profile beyond your master: if your administrator narrows your master profile, your other profiles shrink with it, automatically

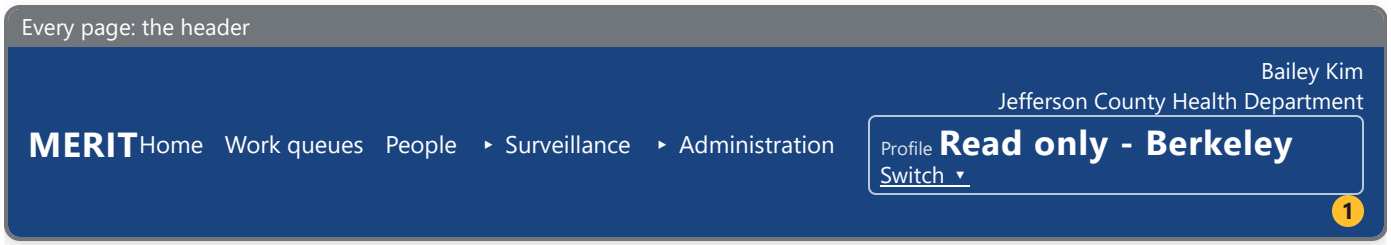
> **MERIT checks this for you.** If you try to save a profile that goes beyond your master profile, MERIT refuses and tells you which part is too big. The database itself enforces your profile's limits, so a read-only profile is truly read-only on every screen.

5. Using profiles: step by step

See which profile you are using

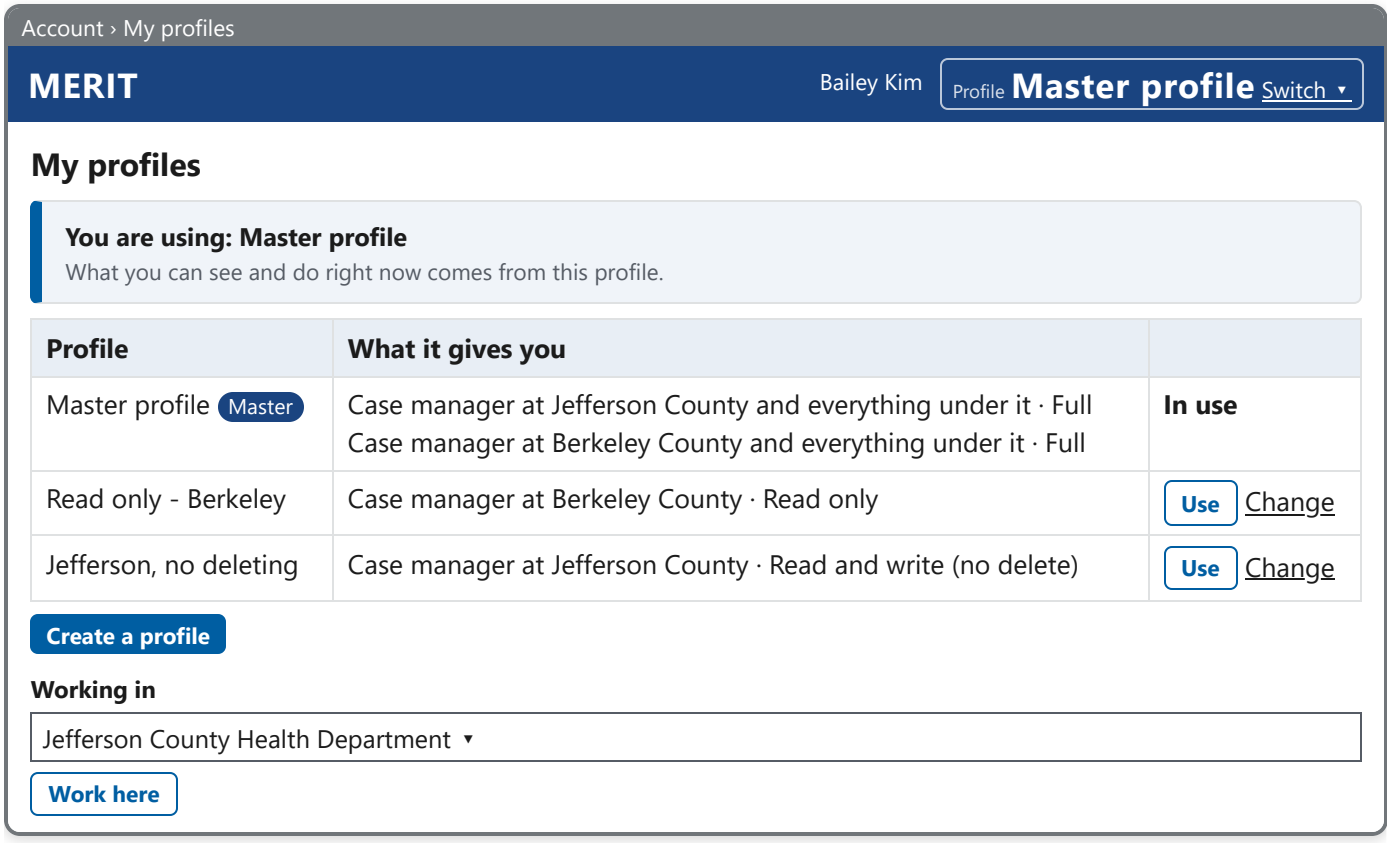
Your profile is always in the header. On smaller screens, open **Menu** to reveal it. The **Administration** menu lists reference levels or configuration, Users, Tenants and the Audit log according to your current profile's permissions; unavailable destinations and empty menus are left out.

The top right of every page shows your name, the place you are working in, and your profile in an outlined box. Select the box (**Switch**) to open **My profiles**.



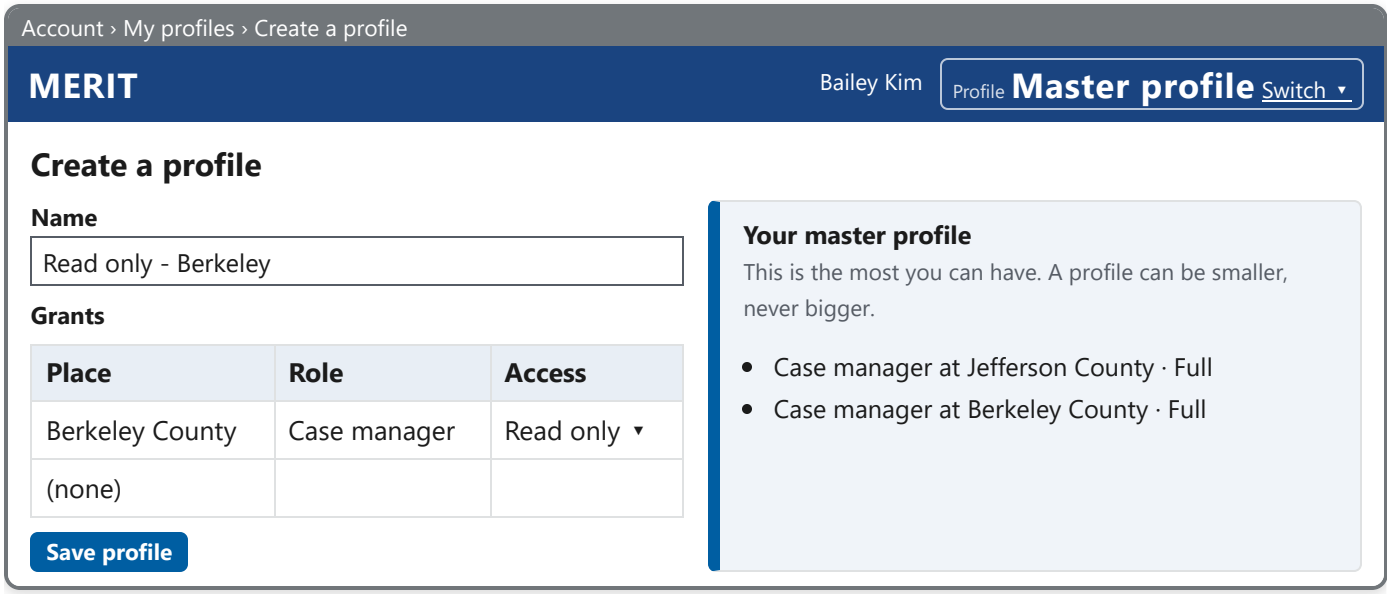
1 Select the profile box to switch or manage your profiles. Beside it, **User guide** opens these guides in a new tab.

My profiles

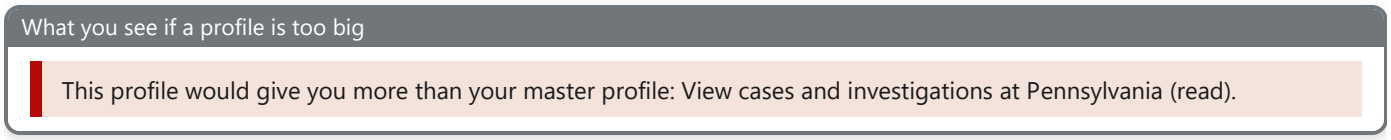


1. Select **Use** next to a profile. MERIT switches straight away; you do not sign out.
2. Everything you see now follows that profile: lists, searches, queues, reports and the buttons on each page.
3. To go back, open **My profiles** and select **Use** next to *Master profile*.

Create a profile



1. Give it a name that says what it is for.
2. Add one or more grants: a place, a role and an access level. The choices come from your master profile.
3. Select **Save profile**. If anything goes beyond your master profile, MERIT says what and does not save.



Change or deactivate a profile

Select **Change** next to a profile. Clear **Active** to hide it from the switcher; you can turn it back on later. Your master profile has no Change link, because only your administrator can change it.

Working in

If your access covers more than one place, choose where new records belong under **Working in**. For example, a region staff member entering a West Virginia result chooses *West Virginia*, so the record uses West Virginia's levels and settings.

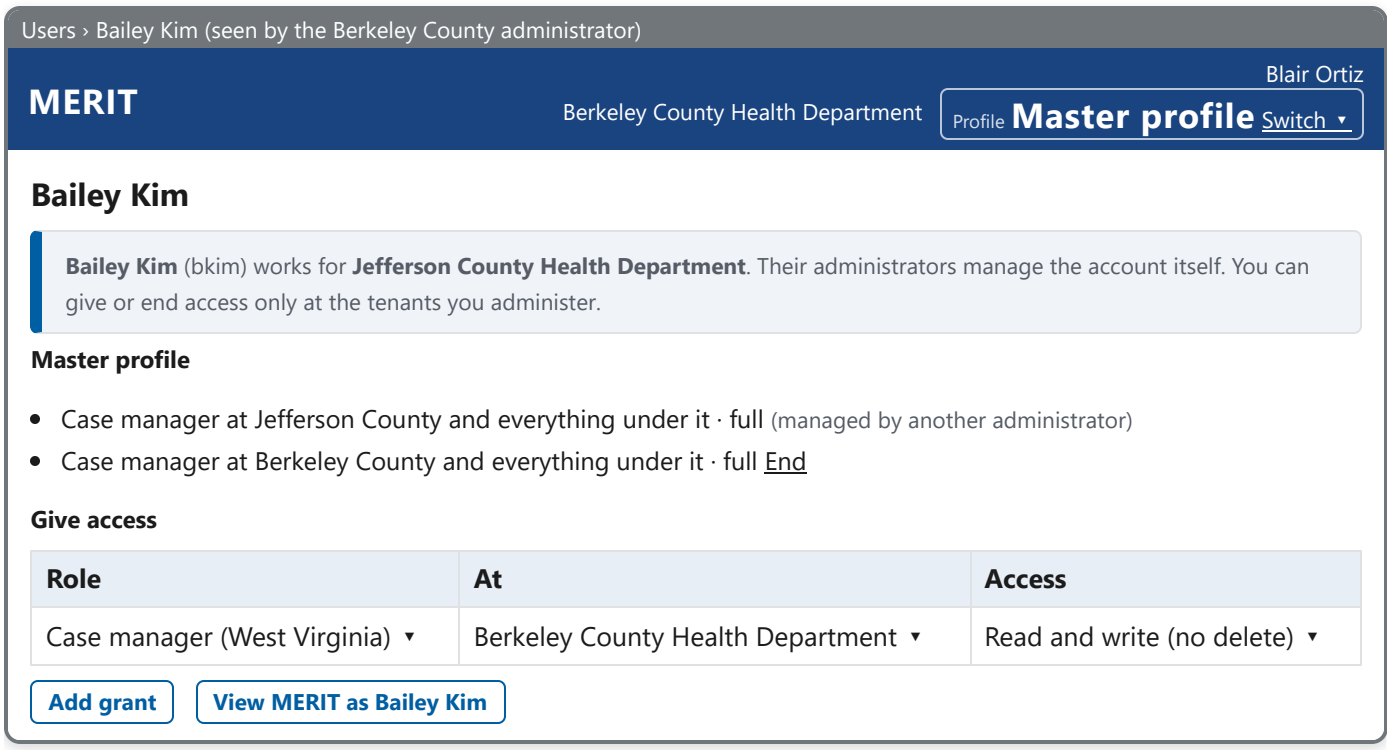
6. For administrators

Add a user

1. Go to **Users** and select **Add a user**.
2. Fill in the name, user name and work email, and choose **Works for**. You can only choose places you administer.
3. Set an initial password. The person sets up an authenticator app the first time they sign in.
4. Under **First access**, choose the person's first grant: a role, the place, the access level and whether it includes everything under it. One save then creates the account with that access. Leave the role on **No access yet** to give access later.
5. Add any further grants on their page under **Give access**. Without a grant the person can sign in but sees nothing, and the page says so.

Give access to someone from another place

Example: Bailey works for Jefferson County but also needs Berkeley County. The Berkeley administrator types Bailey's exact user name in **Give access to someone from another tenant**, opens Bailey's page and adds a Berkeley grant. The Berkeley administrator can see and end only the Berkeley part; Bailey's account itself stays with Jefferson's administrators.



A locked account or a lost authenticator

- **Locked after too many wrong passwords:** on the person's page select **Unlock account**. Their password and authenticator stay as they were.
- **Lost or replaced phone:** the person first tries **Can't access your authenticator?** with a recovery code. If they have none, verify who they are, then select **Reset MFA after verifying the person**. Their old authenticator

and recovery codes stop working and their sessions end; they set up a new authenticator at their next sign-in and save new recovery codes.

- Nobody resets their own second factor: ask another administrator.

Check what someone sees: View as

1. Open the person's page and select **View MERIT as ...** (or use **My profiles** › **View MERIT as someone you manage**).
2. A blue banner appears on every page while you are viewing as them.
3. You see only the parts you manage. A county administrator viewing as Bailey sees Bailey's access in that county only. You never get more than you can do yourself.
4. Anything you do is recorded under **your own name**, noted as "viewing as Bailey".
5. Select **Return to my profile** in the banner to go back.

The view-as banner

You are viewing MERIT as **Bailey Kim**, limited to what you manage. Everything you do is recorded under your own name. **Return to my profile**

7. The platform administrator

The first account created in a new MERIT installation is the platform administrator. It has one purpose: managing accounts.

What the platform administrator sees after signing in

MERIT Users MERIT platform Pat Lee Profile **Master profile**

Users

Name	Works for	Master profile	Status
Reese Grant	EPA Region 3	Administrator @ EPA Region 3; Supervisor @ EPA Region 3	Active
Wren Hall	West Virginia	Administrator @ West Virginia; Supervisor @ West Virginia	Active
Jamie Fox	Jefferson County	User administrator @ Jefferson County; Case manager @ Jefferson County	Active
Bailey Kim	Jefferson County	Case manager @ Jefferson County; Case manager @ Berkeley County	Active

No Cases, Results, Work queues or Reports: the platform administrator sees no records and no health information.

- **Can:** create, change and deactivate any account; give and end any role at any place; reset second factors; and add regions, states, tribes and counties anywhere in the tree on the **Tenants** screen.
- **Cannot:** open, search, add, change or delete any person, result, case, investigation, task or report. MERIT and its database refuse these requests.
- **One profile only:** the platform administrator cannot make other profiles, switch profiles, or view as anyone.

- **Good practice:** keep the number of platform administrators small, and give each regional or state administrator their own account rather than sharing the platform account.

Adding tenants

New agencies join MERIT on the **Tenants** screen (**Tenants** in the top menu). You choose where the new tenant goes, what kind it is, its code and name, and for a county the counties it serves (ticked from the list, or added as new counties under a state). The menu item appears only for people who may add tenants:

Who	Can add	Under
Platform administrator	**Regions, states, tribes, stand-alone jurisdictions; programs and counties**	Anywhere in the tree
Region administrator (Administrator role at a region)	**States and tribes**	Their region
State or tribe administrator (Administrator role)	**Counties, cities and programs**	Their state or tribe, and anything under it
User administrator (for example a county administrator)	**Nothing**	They manage accounts and access only

The permission behind this is **Add tenants** (`tenant.create`). It is part of the Administrator role and the Platform administrator role, and not of the User administrator role. A new state or tribe gets its own roles, settings and counties straight away; a new county shares its state's records and settings. After you add a tenant, give its people access on the **Users** screen.

> **Counties decide who sees whom.** A tenant sees the people who live in the counties it serves. So a tenant added under a county or program can serve only counties its parent already serves, and counties new to MERIT are added under the state or tribe itself. MERIT's database enforces this for everyone, administrators included.

8. Your safety net

- **The database enforces your access,** not just the screens. Even if a screen showed a button by mistake, the database would refuse to show another tenant's records, or to let a read-only profile change anything.
- **Every view, change and export is recorded** with your real name, including while you are viewing as someone else.
- **Deleting hides, it does not destroy.** Deleted records stay in the database, with who deleted them and when.
- **Sessions end when access changes,** so a removed grant stops working straight away.

9. Common questions

I can see Jefferson, but not Berkeley. Why?
Your master profile has a grant for Jefferson only. Ask the Berkeley administrator to give you Berkeley access.

A button I normally use is missing, or a page says Not permitted.
Check the profile in the header. You may be using a read-only or smaller profile. Switch back to your master profile.

After setting up my authenticator, MERIT keeps showing my recovery codes.
That is on purpose: save them (copy or print), tick **I have saved these codes** and choose **Continue to MERIT**. The codes are shown only until then.

Can I give myself Pennsylvania access in a profile?
No. A profile can only be a smaller copy of your master profile.

My administrator changed my access, and I was signed out.
That is on purpose: your new access takes effect at once. Sign in again.

Can my administrator see my password when viewing as me?
No. View as never uses your password or your second factor, and everything the administrator does is recorded under their own name.

Why can't the platform administrator look up a case for me?
Platform administrators manage accounts only, by design. Ask someone with access to that state or county.

Our county was reorganized. Can I add the new health district myself?
Yes, if you hold the Administrator role at the state: open **Tenants**, choose the state, choose **Local jurisdiction**, and tick the counties it serves. County user administrators ask the state administrator.

Region staff: which settings does a new record use?
Those of the place under **Working in**. Choose the state you are entering records for.

MERIT user guide: access, profiles and switching. The examples are illustrative; names and screens are made up.